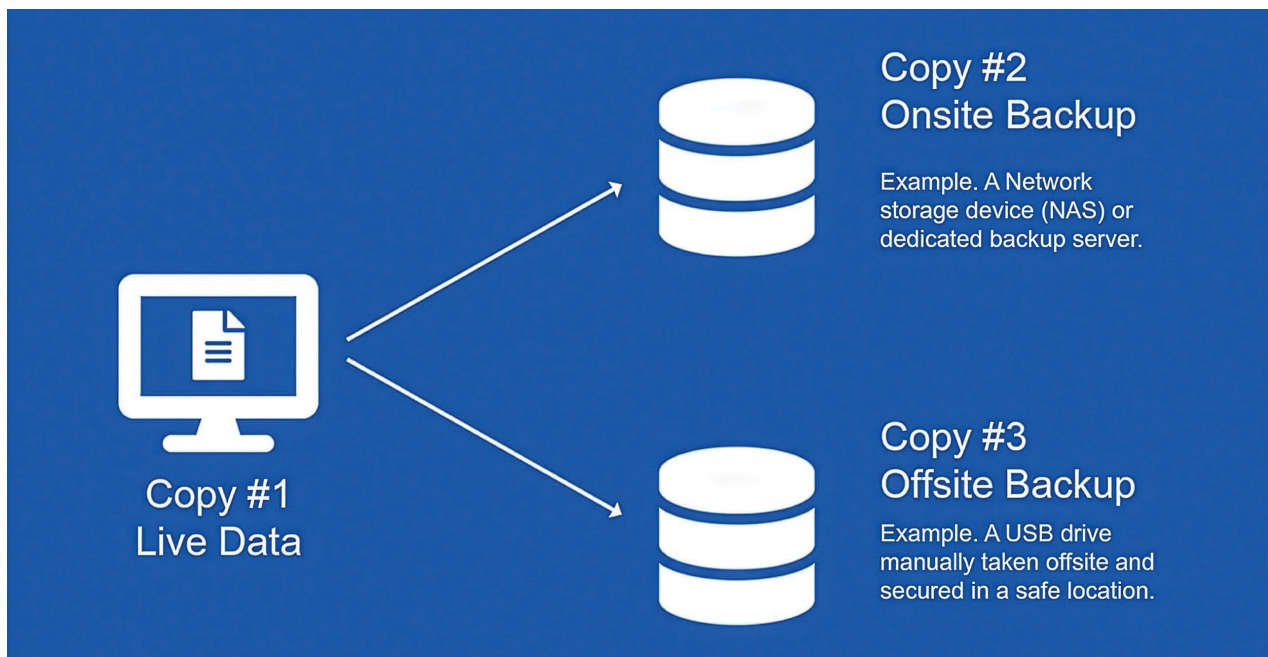




are close to the spirit of the rule. If your important work files live on your Windows PC, and Windows Backup/OneDrive protects key folders while an external SSD holds a periodic manual copy, that is also close. Microsoft says Windows Backup can preserve files, installed apps, settings, themes, Edge preferences, and Wi-Fi information to make restoration easier on a new PC. Apple separately clarifies that iCloud Backup and iCloud Photos work differently: photos may sync through iCloud Photos, while iCloud Backup includes device information that is not already being synced. Understanding those distinctions is what turns checkbox culture into actual protection.

A “good enough” 3-2-1 setup

Imagine a four-person home. Two Android phones, one iPhone, one Windows laptop, maybe an older external drive lying around from a forgotten office purchase. Everyone has photos. Someone has school assignments. Someone has GST invoices. Someone has scanned KYC documents. Someone is pretending the Downloads folder is a filing system.

A sensible version of 3-2-1 for this house could look like this:

- Originals stay on each person’s main device
- Shared essentials get copied to one external SSD or hard drive once a week
- Photos and personal files back up to Google One, iCloud+, or OneDrive depending on platform
- One folder called “Critical Documents” is duplicated locally and in the cloud
- Once a month, somebody checks that the external drive can still open files and that the cloud account has actually finished syncing

This is not enterprise-grade. It is not glamorous. It is also miles better than what many homes currently do, which is effectively: “The phone hasn’t died yet, so perhaps destiny approves.” Google describes Google One storage as extra space for photos, files, and device backups; Apple says iCloud storage is used for backups, photos, files, and more; Microsoft positions OneDrive and Microsoft 365 around cloud storage plus device backup features. These are now mainstream consumer backup rails, not niche tools.

Step-by-step: Build your first 3-2-1 setup

Here is a straightforward way to do it.

Step 1: Identify your must-not-lose data

Create one shortlist:

- family photos and videos
- personal IDs and legal/financial documents
- work files
- college or school documents
- passwords or password-manager exports
- creative projects and invoices

Do not start by backing up everything. Start by protecting what would be painful to recreate. This is in line with NIST’s emphasis on backup files and programs that facilitate recovery after data-loss events.

Step 2: Pick your local backup device

Use an external SSD if speed and portability matter. Use an HDD if budget matters more and the backup will mostly sit at home. The point is not glamour; it is a second local copy on separate hardware. Keep it simple and clearly labelled.